

The Sales Conversation

The exact sales call framework to close
$20k–$100k+ agency and freelance deals

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Welcome.

If you're running an agency, a studio, or working for yourself, this guide will help you to sell more.

It's about the one part of the business that directly decides how much you actually get paid. The sales conversation.

I want to share with you the exact questions to ask a potential client on a call. Get this one area right and everything else gets easier. Bigger projects, better clients, higher prices, more profitable deals.

Because the person asking the questions controls the conversation. And whoever controls the conversation decides where it goes.

So why listen to me?

I run Profitable Skills. I've done over $3.5M in sales myself, and coached over 150 top agency owners and freelancers. Dozens of them have closed single deals over $100k.

But I also know what it is like to struggle.

Ten years ago I was a starting freelancer taking on $150 projects and barely covering rent. I would work all day but was not even making minimum wage.

What I eventually figured out though was it wasn't about my design skills -> it was learning how to sell. $150 projects became $2,000 projects became $20,000+ projects became $100k+ months.

And this is where most people go wrong...

They think the way to grow their business is to keep improving what they sell. So offering better design, or better code, or better branding - or whatever it is that you offer.

But you can "be the best" and still be broke. I see this all the time.

Being good at the work and being good at getting paid for the work are two completely different skills. Yet most people only ever focus on the work side of things.

So you end up with two options:

- You can be the "starving artist". Great at what you do, with nobody to help.
- Or you can learn the business side and build something you actually enjoy running.

And this is good for your clients too. Most of them have been sitting with the same problem for years. They just need someone like you to come in and finally fix it for them.

What you will find in this PDF is the exact call framework I use and teach. And it's one part of a bigger system, but it's the part that can change your income the fastest.

So let's get into it.



Hello, this is me

And I post about getting more sales and leads daily on X



Having the Right Mindset

The price you can charge is capped by what you believe you're worth. Not by your skills.



Two freelancers, same skill level, same years of experience. One charges $5,000 a project, the other charges $50,000. But the work is not ten times better.

The difference is what each of them believes is possible for themselves. And that belief shows up on a sales call long before any numbers get said.

If you're reading this right now and you think $50,000 is a lot of money for what you do, then every potential client you talk to will feel that also. In the way you ask questions, in the way you explain what you do, in the way you recommend what they should spend.

Here is the thing though. There is someone out there who knows less than you, who is charging way more.

So what's the difference?

They decided their work was worth it, and then acted like it. You decided to look around and to follow what everyone else was doing... which often isn't much.

Most people have this backwards. They wait and they wait for a client or "the market" to tell them to raise their prices. But, that never happens. People will gladly pay you less than they should for as long as you let them.

So before your next sales call, take some time with these questions and write down real answers...



What is the biggest result a client has ever got from my work?



What was that result worth to their business, roughly, in money?



What would they have kept struggling with if I had not helped?



What is the highest price I feel comfortable saying out loud?



Where did that number actually come from? Is it really a fact?



What would I have to believe to double that number?



What actions can I take to show myself I am that person already?



What would I need to say on a call for a client to believe in that price?



What would a client need to see before we spoke to already believe I was worth that price?



Call Preparation

A little preparation goes a long way with selling. Your goal before starting any sales call is to have a good idea of your potential client's business and what they might be working towards.

This does two things. It helps you ask sharper questions on the call, and clients can always tell whether you did your research. Turning up knowing their business already puts you ahead of most people they have spoken to.

But you will only find their exact problems once you are talking to them. So do not try to diagnose anything yet. The problems come later. For now it is just about showing you are sharp and that you did your research.

What you want going into the call is a clear picture of who they are, what they do, who they sell to, and why their customers buy from them.

For every call, give this fifteen or twenty minutes. I have done over 1,000 sales calls and I still do this before every single call. Yes, it is that important.

What to ask yourself during your research...



What exactly does this business do?



What are their main services, products, or offers?



Who do they help?



Which of their customers are worth the most to them?



Why are their ideal customers looking for help in the first place?



What would help these ideal customers to choose this business?



What is needed for this business to be "the best" in this niche?



How would someone decide if this business was right for them?



How do they currently turn interest into actual sales?



What are the biggest gaps you can see relevant to what you offer?



How might you help this business grow, improve, or scale more?

At first this takes time. But the more you do it the faster it gets -> and turning up already understanding their business puts you ahead of almost everyone else.

03

Setting the Frame

> **The word "frame" refers to the assumed context of a situation.**



You are now prepared to begin the actual sales conversation. And to have an effective sales conversation, your first goal should be to "set the frame".

The word "frame" here refers to the assumed context of a situation. It is the unspoken rules of how people will likely behave depending on the different situations they are in.

For example, compare the different frames of you going to church versus a gym versus a fancy restaurant. You're the same person in each situation but act very differently because the rules of that environment change.

And you can use this same principle to give you a massive advantage when selling. You can set the frame that this is a consultative call. This means that you're asking the questions, and the client is answering them.

This might sound manipulative, but it is not.

It is how things are done when you go to visit any doctor, dentist, or lawyer. You sit down, they ask about your problems, and then they give you a solution.

It should be no different for you when you are selling. You need to find out what is wrong with the client's business and how you should best help them. So you need to be in control.

With this concept of frames in mind, let's look at how to kick off a sales conversation...

Part 1 - Get the client talking

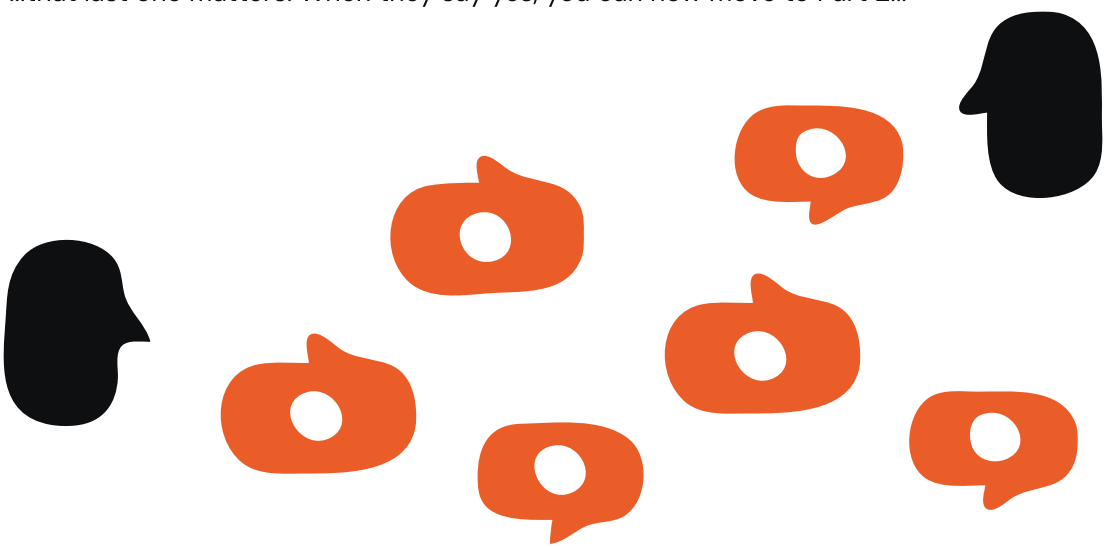
The first two or three minutes decide how the rest of the call goes. You want to open things up, let them talk for a moment, and then move to set the frame...

Hey [name], great to talk. How has your week been going so far?

And whereabouts are you based? [Or a similar friendly question]

...Okay cool. Well, we can jump right into it if you want?

...that last one matters. When they say yes, you can now move to Part 2...



Part 2 - Set the frame

Once they say yes, you set the frame straight away. Something like this:



"So, how this will go is I'll ask you some questions about your business and what you are working on, so I understand everything properly.

Then if it sounds like I can help, I'll go through some options with you and how that all works.

And then at the end you can decide if it's something you want to do or not.

Does that sound all good to you?"

Then stop talking and wait for them to answer.

If the client **agrees** (which they nearly always will), the frame is set. You are the one asking the questions from here.

If the client **disagrees**, something is off. Either they weren't expecting a sales conversation, or there is another issue. Do not push forward. Find out what the problem is first.

So in just a few words you have set up the type of conversation that gives you the best chance of closing, and hinted at them making a decision at the end. And by agreeing to it, they have handed you control of the call without either of you making a thing of it.



04

Understanding the Context

> You can't find a problem people will pay to solve if you don't first know where to look.

To create a sale, you must find important problems that your potential clients will be willing to invest in fixing. But to find those problems, you must first know where to look.

Which makes the goal of this stage of a sales conversation all about context. You need to quickly understand the client's situation and get an overall idea of their business.

Think of it like getting the map before you go looking for treasure. Without one, you are just digging in random places and hoping something shows up.

So use the following questions to quickly understand their overall situation. Once you have a clear idea of what is going on in the business, you can move ahead.

And keep it broad here. You are not diagnosing anything yet. You are getting the big picture so that later, when you go deeper, you have something to connect it all back to.

So, let's look at some good context questions...



How is your business doing at the moment?



What have you been working on the last while?



How has that been going? Are you happy with the results you are getting?



What are your plans for the next 6-12 months?



Do you have any top projects or goals at the moment?



Where is your main focus right now with the business?



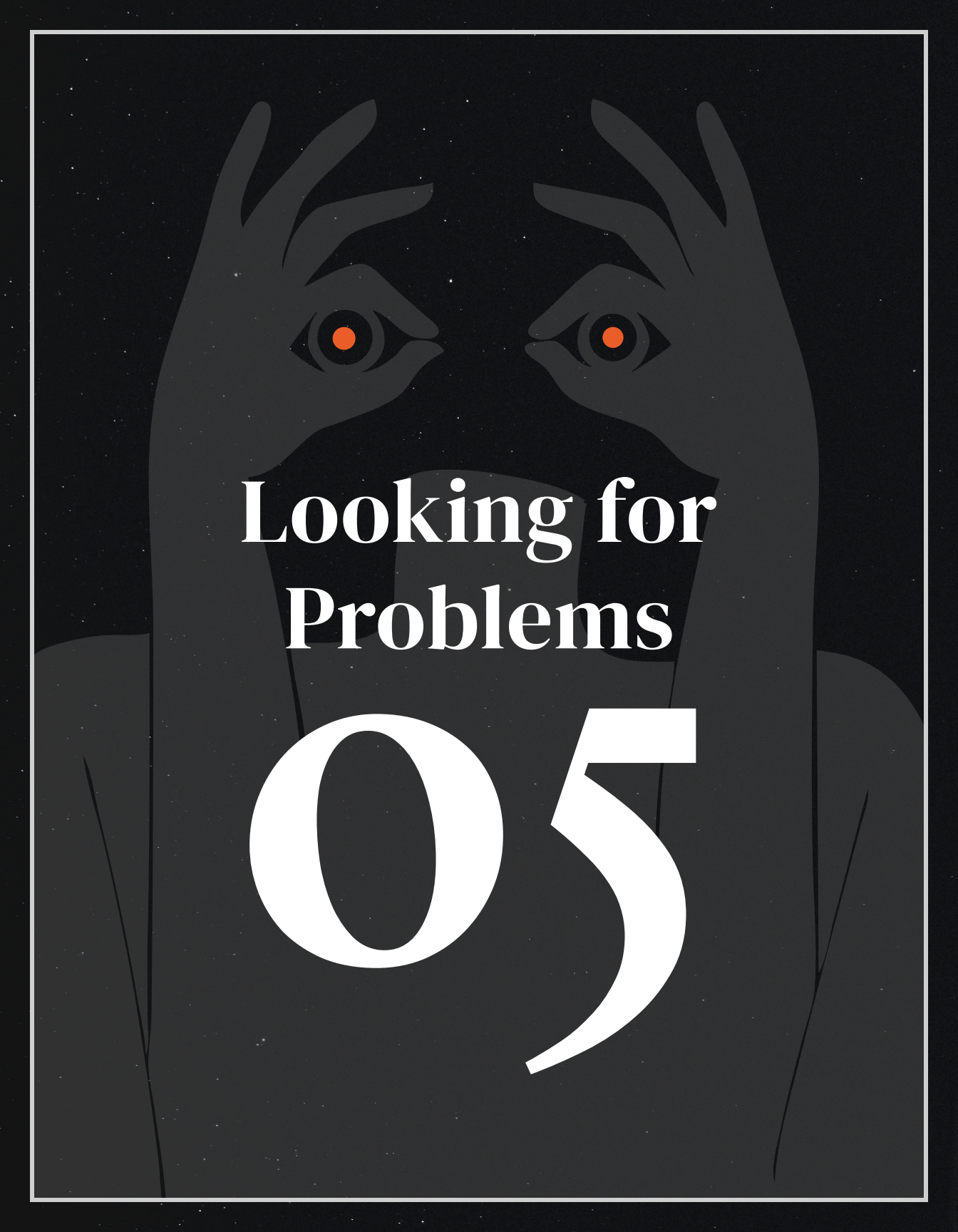
And what do you feel you need the most help with at the moment?

These questions are excellent for bringing up topics you can potentially help with. The client should start to mention different problems, challenges, obstacles and goals.

Now, you do not have to ask all of these. Just enough to see where their business is at.

And as they talk, either write down or remember what is most relevant to you. Because in the next stage, the very next goal is to focus in more on the areas where you have the best chances of finding problems that you can build a sale on top of.

Once you have enough context to see where to focus, you are ready to move forward.



Looking for Problems

05

> **Every business has another level they want to get to. That gap is where your sale lives.**

No matter what stage a client's business is at, there is always another level they want to get to. They want to sell more, get better clients, make things easier to run, or be more profitable.

And this is a good thing. Those problems are the raw fuel you use to create a sale.

So the next goal is to start finding them. You want to see where they are stuck, struggling, stressed, or unsatisfied. The more you find, and the bigger they are, the easier the sale becomes.

The good news is you do not have to force this. These questions follow naturally from the context stage, so as they talk about what they are working on, you just focus more on the parts where problems are likely to be. And keep it relevant, meaning problems you can actually help with.

One thing to watch here though. The moment a client says a problem out loud, the temptation is to jump in and try to fix it for them. Do not do this.

I have directly taught hundreds of freelancers and agency owners how to sell, and the pattern is always the same -> the calls where you start trying to solve things early are the calls that run long and end with nothing.

Just say "okay" and ask the next question. You are not here to solve anything yet. At this stage you are only finding out what is wrong.

How to find possible problems to solve...



"...okay, so it looks like _____ is the main goal right now. What have been the challenges with that so far?"



"...and have you tried anything already to fix that? How did that go?"



"...what do you see as the main thing holding you back there?"



"...and how long has that been going on for?"



"...okay, I can see you are very focused on _____. So what is the next stage there to get [the result they want]?"

The idea here is to take what they were talking about in the context stage and go in closer on the areas where they are likely to have problems you can help with.

So keep your own skills and services in mind as you do this. There is no point digging into a problem you cannot solve. You are only looking for the ones you can actually fix.

Do this right and the client is now talking about problems that connect directly to what you offer. That is exactly where you want to be, because the next stage is going deeper into those problems to see the real damage they are doing.

06

Finding the Real Damage

> **A problem that you can't measure is also a problem that nobody will pay to fix.**

Okay, so at this stage the client is starting to talk about their problems. That is a great start, but you must go deeper to build a strong sale.

Think of this like going to the dentist. If you tell them your teeth hurt, they don't just go right to a solution. Instead they put you in the chair, ask questions, check everything, take X-rays.

It's the same idea here. You must fully understand the client's problems and the damage being done to their business and life. The more you know, the stronger your chances of a sale.

Because here is what most people miss. A client does not buy because they have a problem. Everyone has problems and most of them sit there for years. They buy when the problem finally feels big enough, expensive enough, and annoying enough to be worth doing something about.

And they won't get there on their own. Or they would have done it themselves already.

That is what this stage is for. You are helping them see the full size of something they have been carrying around and mostly ignoring. By seeing the full damage, you get them ready to take action.

And still do not solve anything here. It gets hardest at this stage, because now you can see what is wrong and how you would fix it. Sit on it. Every problem you solve here is one you cannot charge for later.

What to ask to go deeper into their problems...



"...okay, I see, and what exactly is the issue with that...?"



"...I understand, so can you tell me more about that? What exactly has been the problem?"



"...okay, and have you tried anything so far to help fix that?"



"...and how long has this been a problem?"



"...do you see this as an urgent problem to fix right now? Why do you feel that is so?"

As you go through these questions, you are digging around for ALL the damage these problems are doing. You want the direct damage and the indirect damage. Everything.

And take your time here. It is worth fully understanding what annoys and frustrates the client the most, because that is what your whole sale gets built on.

Remember, clients only pay to fix problems they find serious, frustrating, and urgent. So make sure you have dug well enough before moving to the next stage.

07

Seeing What It Is Costing Them



> **People spend money a lot faster to STOP losing than they do to start gaining.**

A lot of freelancers and agency owners struggle with pricing. They just don't know how much to charge a client. In this section, I will show you how to get started with making pricing a lot easier.

And it begins with seeing how much their problems are costing them.

You see, a problem isn't really worth anything until there is a cost directly connected to it. So to justify getting paid a certain amount to fix it, you need to show they are losing more than that amount by leaving it alone.

People spend money a lot faster to STOP losing than they do to start gaining. So, while you want to show what they can gain, you definitely want to show them the cost of not fixing this.

And there are three types of cost...

→ The direct cost, which is money going out the door right now
→ The hidden cost, which is time and missed opportunities, usually bigger
→ And the future cost, which is what this looks like in a year if nothing changes

But the key is that the client says the numbers, not you.

Tell someone their problem costs them $10k a month and they will argue. Let them say it and it becomes a fact they have to act on.

How to find the hidden cost of a problem...



"...so you mentioned [problem]. How much business do you think that is costing you each month?"



"...and how many new clients do you feel you are missing out on each month because of it?"



"...okay, and what would each of those clients be worth to you?"



"...if you don't fix this, how much time and energy do you feel you are wasting? And what would you put on that in a dollar amount each month?"



"...so is it safe to say this problem is costing you around $_____ each month?"



"...and looking back over the last year or two, what number would you put on the total damage it has done so far?"

You do not need to ask all of these. Pick one or two that fit the conversation.

But do get to a number. This is the part most people skip, and it is the reason their price feels expensive later.



Looking at What They Want Instead

> **People pay to stop the pain.
> But they buy the future.**

If you have made it to this stage of the sale, you are well over halfway. You understand the client's situation, their problems, and the cost of them not taking action.

This now leaves you with a clear next goal. To find out what they want instead.

You see, it is great to know what people don't want. And that is a massive part of creating a sale. But to actually motivate someone to take action, you must also know what their dream goals are.

Imagine it this way. Someone just broke their leg and is in a LOT of pain. That is the problem. But if you try to move them, they will panic and tell you they can't. The pain is too much.

To get them to act, you need to give them a reason worth moving for. "If you come with me, we can get you to a hospital, they can help you get fixed, and then the pain stops."

Same thing here. The problems you found earlier are what make them want to move. But to get them to actually take action, there needs to be a clear end goal in mind.

So your job now is to get them describing that end goal properly. Not a vague idea of things being better, but a specific picture of where they want the business to be. The clearer it gets, the more they want it.

How to get them to map out their goals...



"...and what exact results would you like to have if these problems were fully fixed?"



"...so with this out of the way, where would you like to take the business next?"



"...let's say we can get this fixed. Can you tell me exactly what you would like to see happen?"



"...if we could get this all fixed and back on track, what is the dream place you would like to get the business to?"

Then ask for even more details about why these results matter...



"...okay, so you would love to have [result]. Why does this matter most to you at the moment?"



"...and how exactly would that help you and the business the most?"



"...okay, so you want [result]. And what is it about [result] that you are after the most?"



"...and why is [result] so key for the business to focus on next?"



09

Looking at What Their Dream Outcome is Worth

> **Knowing what a result is worth to a potential client means you can offer the perfect deal - at the perfect price.**

Earlier, we talked about looking at what a client's problem is actively costing them. Now, at this stage, you must also investigate what their dream outcome is worth to them.

Imagine this like selling a house. Someone tells you all the details about their dream property... four bedrooms, lots of natural light, a big garden. But do they have $300,000 to spend or $10 million? The amount changes what you will actually present to them.

It is the same on a sales call. A client who says "it would be nice to get more clients" makes it very hard to price a project. But a client who says "getting another 6-8 clients a month would be huge, that's like an extra $40k" has just told you exactly what your work is worth to them. You now have clear signals to create a budget that makes sense.

And this is where most people go wrong with pricing. They price off what the work costs them to deliver. Hours, effort, what they charged the last client. But the client is not buying "the work". They are buying a result, and that result has a value that has nothing to do with how long it takes you.

There is also a second thing to look for here. Along with the money, what would this result mean to them personally? Less stress, less worry about where the next client comes from, the business finally feeling under control.

The numbers make it logical to invest in. The emotional side makes it feel like the right move personally. And to close bigger deals, you want both.

How to put a number on what they want...



"...okay, so you just mentioned your goal was _____. So how much extra revenue or customers do you hope that will create for the business each month?"



"...and if you could make that happen, what are you hoping to boost your revenue to?"



"...and how much time and effort do you think getting this result will save you?"



"...okay, and by how much do you think that extra time and effort could help grow the business?"



"...so let's say you were able to do all of this. By what percentage do you feel you could grow? And to understand that better, what rough amount would that be?"

Again, only use some of these. Asking all of them would be too much.

What matters is that you get a real number out of it. "Yeah, it should help the business" gives you nothing to work with. But "that would probably be another $25k a month" gives you everything, because now you have something solid to build a price around.

And if they cannot put a number on it themselves, help them get there. Ask what one client is worth, or what a month at their current rate looks like, and work it out together. Most business owners have never actually done that maths, and doing it out loud with you is often the moment the whole thing becomes real to them.

10

Pricing the Deal



> **Perfect pricing is about being able to see the gap between the cost of a problem and the value of a desired result.**

Okay, you are now at a key moment in the sales conversation. And you have plenty of information to guide you at this point.

You know about the client's business and all their problems. You also know the results they want and how much those results are worth to them.

And here is why all that work matters. Most people go into the pricing part of a call with nothing. Their plan is to say some number and hope the client is okay with it. But you are now going in with the client's own words about what is broken, what it is costing them, and what fixing it is worth.

So your price is not a guess. It sits in the gap between those two numbers, and you can show exactly why. To the client it feels directly based on their own situation.

The freelancers and agency owners I coach who make the jump from $10k projects to $50k+ projects are able to price much higher because of this approach. Their suggested budget is no longer a guess, it is a well presented argument.

Now, this is a short guide, so I am not going to cover every pricing scenario in here. What each deal looks like depends on their problems and what your offer actually is.

But let me show you the general idea of how to set things up correctly...

Part 1 - Ask for their budget...



"...okay, thank you for sharing so much.

I now want to go over what amount you think is best to invest in fixing these problems and getting the results that you want...

...so with the problems we talked about [mention the problems]...
...and seeing the damage they are doing [mention the cost]...
...and then also the results you want [mention the dream results]...
...and how it can help your business [mention the value]...

...what amount did you have in mind for a budget, so I can then look at the best options available to you?"

This looks like a lot to say, but it will flow better when you have real information to use.

Before you mention any number, you are stacking up everything they told you. Their problems, their cost, their goals, their value. All in their own words.

So by the time you ask about budget, they're not thinking about what your work costs. They are thinking about what fixing all of that is worth.

And that is why you ask them first. If you say a number before they do, you have capped the deal at whatever you guessed. Let them go first and you often find they were thinking bigger than you were.

Part 2 - Gauge and adjust...

Once you ask that question, the client will do one of three things...

→ **They give a good number.** Okay great, but don't rush ahead. Take a minute and reinforce why you agree that budget makes sense.

"Perfect... ya with that kind of investment we can properly tackle this and get you on track for that target."

→ **They give a low number.** Annoying, but don't argue with it. Instead, take a minute and go back over their own numbers.

"...okay, so I just want to go back over what you said, because with this costing you around $30k a month, and your goal being an extra $50k in revenue... in my experience, to get this done properly and have the best chance of hitting those results, the investment usually needs to be closer to..."

→ **They have no idea.** This is actually a great position, because you then get to frame the right budget yourself. Just make sure to give them a number that is anchored to their situation and the results they want, NOT to your costs.

"Based on what you've shared and what I've seen work for similar businesses, something like this usually sits between $X and $Y..."

Important: If they don't have a high enough budget, don't drop your price. Change the scope instead. Offer less for now, at the same rates. It is far better to sort out any budget issues live on the call than to hope it's okay and send an invoice they were never going to say yes to, and then spend two weeks wondering why.

Part 3 - Present the plan...

"...okay, so based on everything you have told me, let me go over what I think makes the most sense here.

So step one, we would fix [problem]. That is the one costing you [their damage]...

...then step two, we would set up [thing], which is what gets you moving towards [their goal]...

[keep going through your plan, showing how each part gets them what they want and removes the problems they told you about]

...and the whole thing usually takes around [timeframe].

So how does all of that sound? Is it roughly what you had in mind?"

Give one clear recommendation, not a menu of options. They came to you for a decision, so tell them what you think is best.

And tie every part of the plan back to something they actually said. Each step should remove a problem they named or move them towards a goal they described. If a part does not do either, cut it.

Then check their reaction to the plan **before** you say any budget numbers. Once they are happy with the plan, then give the price and stop talking. This way you can see if any issues are on the plan side or on the price side. It's best to do this separately.

11

Testing the Sale



> **Most bad deals don't die on the call. They die in the weeks after it.**

A big mistake a lot of freelancers make is rushing the final stages of a sales call. Once a client kind of says they're interested, they want to get off the call as fast as possible and hope it closes.

But this is risky, and it is very likely you will run into issues later.

Why? Because you never stress tested the deal. You never looked for the hidden questions, concerns or objections.

And there will nearly always be a few. When a potential client says "yeah, sounds good" at the end of a call, that is often not a real yes. They are saying yes just to be polite. Or because they don't feel comfortable bringing any issues or concerns up with you.

So your goal is to get them okay with saying whatever is on their mind right now. Otherwise it will wreck the deal a week later, when you're no longer live on the call to deal with it.

So after you have gone over the plan and the price, your job is to check first, not close.

Just ask them openly and in a relaxed way: "is there anything you are not fully sure about...? Does the focus and the plan and the price all sound good to you...?"

Then if something does come up, good. That is them telling you exactly what is standing between you and a yes.

How to best finish the sales conversation...



"...Okay, so does all of this sound good to you? Did you have any questions or concerns to go over?"



"...And what about the problems we talked about? Is this what you see as most important to fix for your business right now, or did we miss anything else?"



"...okay, and was there anything else you think to cover or are you happy with me to work with the information I already have and then come back to you with some options?"

Ask one or two of these, not all of them. You are just giving them room to say anything they have not said yet.

If something does come up, deal with it now. "I need to think about it" and "I need to talk to my partner" both mean something is unresolved, so ask what it is. "Sure, what part are you thinking over the most?" And if it is the price, do not drop it. Go back over their own numbers, and if it still does not fit, change the scope instead.

One thing worth knowing though. If a concern will not move no matter what you say, that is a signal -> the earlier stages were not deep enough. The problem never felt big enough, or the value was never clear.

Once all of this is clear, you are nearly finished with the sales conversation. Let's now look at what is left to do...



Ending the Call

Once you have tested the sale, you are pretty much ready to finish the call.
But there are a few last things to cover, so let's go over those.

#1 - Set a clear plan the client understands

Always name a day or a specific timeline. "I will be in touch" or "let me know when you are ready" leaves it up to them. You want a set deadline to both be on the same page.

> **"...okay great, so I will now go over everything you said and put together the best options for you. Are you okay if I get back to you this Thursday with a complete plan?**
>
> **And then are you free for a quick call on Friday to go through it?"**

So, in this example there are two dates -> one to send it, one to go through it together.
This is what you want to aim for when wrapping up a call. Clear next steps and dates.

#2 - Thank them for their time

> **"...okay, great. Thanks for the talk, and I appreciate you sharing all of this with me. I will go over this all and will [first step of plan] on the [date]"**

#3 - End the call

Don't overstay your welcome. Say goodbye and finish the call.

Next Steps

Well done on finishing the full sales conversation framework.

Used properly, this exact framework gives you a much better chance of landing bigger clients, better projects, and more profitable deals.

I have used it myself to do over $3.5M in sales, and I have taught it to over 150 agency owners and freelancers who currently do several million in deals per month between them.

But here is the part I want to be honest with you about... A good sales framework only matters if you have suitable leads to talk to.

Which is what I can help you with. I run a full program where we work together to:

→ Position yourself so you are the obvious choice, not one of five quotes
→ Build a content system that brings in qualified leads every week
→ Set up the funnels that get more of those leads onto calls with you
→ Move from $10k projects to $50k+ projects on the same work
→ Fix the follow up so deals stop dying in the week after the call
→ Get off referrals and onto lead flow you actually control

Within a year of working together, a lot of my clients have doubled or tripled their business and hit their best ever months in sales and profits.

Thanks for reading, and apply below if you want to talk about working together.

- Rob

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